reader begins by knowing nothing of the story one is going to tell.

I prepared my talk meticulously, therefore, from first principles. I went into the seminar room some hours before the talk, and covered all the boards with equations and chemical formulas. One student, stumbling into the room as I was finishing, looked at the mass of hieroglyphics with dismay and said, "111 never understand this."

I said, soothingly, "Nonsense. Just listen to everything I say and all will be as clear as a mountain pool."

What made me so sure of that, I don't know, but that's how it was. I gave the talk from the beginning and moved slowly along all the equations and formulas, without having to suffer the distraction and interruption of having to write them down as I talked.

In the end the audience seemed enthusiastic and Professor Dawson told someone (who promptly passed it on to me) that it was the clearest presentation he had ever heard. It happened to be the first time I ever presented a formal hour-long talk to an audience in my life.

20

My father turned fifty on December 21, and my father's birthday always meant Christmas and the end of the year.

The year 1946 had ended far better than it had begun, but it was not one of my more successful writing years. I had sold only two short stories (both in the positronic robot series) and nothing more. That

was not surprising. Between the Army in the first part of the year and research in the second, there had been little writing time.

Even so, my two anthology sales and my sale to Orson Welles raised my total writing income for 1946 to $718. There was also my Army pay, Gertrude's Army allotment, her earnings at the Henry Paper Box Company, and the money I got from the GI Bill of Rights. It all came to between $2,000 and $3,000 and, with the writing earnings added, our bank account did not suffer that year.

21

On January 2, 1947, I was twenty-seven years old. It was a wonderful